Zine-ify your Research

A companion zine to a workshop by

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more stuff at:
bit.ly/rdds-zine-workshop

STEP ONE

OUTLINE your ZINE

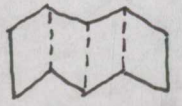
→ What is your topic?
→ What is the most important thing you want readers to know or to do?
→ How will you organize it?
· By argument?
· By takeway?
· By piece of evidence?
List them!
→ Will you include a notes section or bibliography?

STEP TWO

CHOOSE your FORMAT

→ Will you make your zine by hand (like this one) or digitally?
→ How many pages will you need? (The fewer, the better)

TIPS!



- Zines come in many shapes and sizes. This is a minizine. You can find examples of 1/4 and 1/2 page zines online. Logistically, it's best for your number of pages to be a multiple of 4.

STEP THREE

SUMMARIZE WHAT YOU WANT TO SAY

→ Break it down page-by-page
→ Condense your text, then condense it again
→ Write for clarity
· cut any jargon
· include section headers
· convey your interest and other reader signposts
· consider including anecdotes and personal perspectives
· define or explain specialist concepts and terms
→ Use a writing clarity tool to simplify your text

STEP FOUR

ADD VISUAL INTEREST

→ Are there ways you can convey meaning through graphics, illustrations, color, spacing, etc.?
→ Get creative! page borders and backgrounds lend themselves to collage and sketches
→ You can make zines by hand or digitally with tools like Canva or Adobe Frescо (or both!) Each has a different feel. Experiment!

STEP FIVE

FINAL TOUCHES

→ If you will make your zine available digitally as a PDF, strongly consider making sure it is accessible to low or no-vision readers.
→ Printing and folding can be tricky. There are a ton of tutorials online.
→ Formatting can be done manually or with tools like Nash High's "Zine Arranger" ♡
→ Consider using shortlinks or QR codes for hyperlink accessibility
→ Embrace imperfection! It's a hallmark of the genre

STEP SIX

DISTRIBUTE YOUR ZINE

→ Choose a Creative Commons license or other and include it on the cover
→ Make copies and fold to share
· hand out at conferences
· leave in random places (coffee shops, Little Free Libraries, etc.)
· give it to loved ones!
→ Upload it to a personal website, an institutional repository, or sites like Knowledge Commons
→ Submit it to zine-friendly journals and conferences

MORE TIPS

→ Have fun with it! There are no rules!
→ Be proud of the thing you made!

With inspiration from Julia Setele, Jex Calvert, Sarah Mirk, and Tulane Libraries

This zine created by Cynthia Heider 2026
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